Study Materials

Written Exposure Therapy for Transdiagnostic Anxiety

Participant-facing materials for the Written Exposure Therapy transdiagnostic-anxiety study.

This document describes every material presented to participants: the screening procedure, the consent and comprehension procedure, the questionnaire battery, the intervention itself, the follow-ups, and qualitative reflection items collected during the study. For each published scale we give the exact instruction stem, the response anchors as displayed, the number of items, and a citation to the source publication where the full item wording is available. Items from published scales are not reproduced verbatim. Study-designed materials that are short are reproduced in this document; longer ones (the CTSI core-threat elicitation protocol and the WET and NIW psychoeducation + writing instructions) are provided as separate rendered files alongside this document.

Demographic information (age, sex, ethnicity, country, employment) was collected by Prolific at the participant-account level and returned to us as metadata; participants did not complete a study-administered demographic instrument. These fields are documented in the data codebook (see `demographics.data.csv`).

Contents

1. What participants saw at each timepoint
2. Consent and comprehension
3. Screening procedure
4. Symptom and functioning measures
5. Hypothesised mechanisms
6. Intervention procedure
7. Post-writing and session-wrap items
8. Follow-up sessions
9. Qualitative feedback items
10. Materials administered but not analysed in this report

What participants saw at each timepoint

The study had seven contact points. Screening determined eligibility. Sessions 1–4 delivered the writing intervention. One-week and two-month follow-ups assessed durability.

Block	**Screen**	**S1**	**S2**	**S3**	**S4**	**1wk**	**2mo**
Consent	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Prolific ID	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Comprehension check (protocol/payment structure)		✓					
Welcome / orientation		✓					
OASIS	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
WSAS	✓	✓			✓	✓	✓
PHQ-9 (eligibility)	✓						
Brief PCL-5 (eligibility, conditional)	✓						
DIAMOND delusion/hallucination items (eligibility)	✓						
Embedded attention-check items (eligibility)	✓						
DTS		✓			✓		
TAF-R		✓			✓		
BCSS (24 items, 4 subscales)		✓			✓		
IFES		✓			✓		
MCQ-30		✓			✓		
SCS-SF		✓			✓		
Core-threat elicitation (CTSI)		✓					
Treatment Credibility (4 think + 2 feel items)		✓					
BSAM, pre-writing (after imagining core-threat script)		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Fear-script evaluation, pre-writing (5 items, not analysed)		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
WET / NIW psychoeducation		✓					
20-minute writing task		✓	✓	✓	✓		
Within-writing distress rating (slider, not analysed)		✓	✓	✓	✓		
BSAM, post-writing		✓	✓	✓	✓		
Fear-script evaluation, post-writing (5 items, not analysed)		✓	✓	✓	✓		
Session-wrap reflection (3 open-ended items, not analysed)		✓	✓	✓	✓		
Daily belief and behaviour probes (S2, S3 only, not analysed)			✓	✓			
End-of-session debrief		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Commitment-to-return item		✓	✓	✓	✓		
Impact / skill-transfer prompts (2 items, analysed qualitatively)							✓
Nightmare-description block (S4 only, not analysed)					✓		

Block	Screen	S1	S2	S3	S4	1wk	2mo
Study-feedback prompt (S4 only, analysed qualitatively)					✓		

S1–S4 = sessions 1 through 4. Screen = screening. 1wk / 2mo = follow-ups.

Notes on the table:

- Sessions 2 and 3 abbreviate the session-1 structure: consent, pre-writing BSAM + fear-script eval, writing task with a mid-task distress rating and the three reflection questions, post-writing BSAM + fear-script eval, OASIS, two sliders probing belief and behaviour during the day (see Materials administered but not analysed), and debrief with the commitment item.
- Session 4 administers the full writing protocol (evaluate_pre → writing → evaluate_post). In session 1 the OASIS and the full mechanism battery are administered *before* the writing protocol; in session 4 they are administered *after* it. This change in ordering (present at session 4 only) was a procedural choice made before data collection. Session 4 also includes the iBAT protocol after the mechanism battery, a nightmare-description block (not analysed), and an open-ended study-feedback prompt (analysed qualitatively; see Qualitative feedback items).
- Consent was re-presented at the start of every session including both follow-ups; Prolific ID was re-captured at every session.
- The waitlist group followed an equivalent schedule of assessment-only contacts (no psychoeducation, no writing) at timepoints matched to the active arms.
- The one-week follow-up administers consent, BSAM + fear-script eval, OASIS, WSAS, and a brief thank-you debrief — no writing task.
- The two-month follow-up adds TIII (not analysed) and two open-ended items about intervention impact and skill transfer (analysed qualitatively; see Qualitative feedback items).
- "Fear-script evaluation items" are five self-designed items about the script itself (likelihood, valence, stressfulness, vividness, coherence). Administered before and after every writing session and at both follow-ups alongside the BSAM. Not analysed in this report; described below for completeness.

Consent and comprehension

Consent

The consent form was presented at the screening stage and at the start of every subsequent session, including the two follow-ups. The full text is reproduced in consent.md.

Comprehension check

Before beginning the main session 1 protocol, participants completed a brief two-question comprehension check on the multi-part study structure and payment arrangements (not the study content or hypotheses). The two questions were:

1. A multiple-choice question about when the £5.00 bonus payment would be awarded (correct answer: after completing all five parts of the study, including the one-week follow-up).
2. A multiple-select question about what participants would be asked to do next (correct answer: a further writing task, in 1–2 days, lasting 30 minutes, repeated three more times that week).

The check was for payment/protocol understanding only.

Screening procedure

Prospective participants completed an online screening survey via Prolific. A screening-stage consent form (substantively similar to the main-study consent but tailored to the short screening timeframe and its separate compensation) was presented first, followed by the eligibility instruments listed below. Decisions were made automatically by a scoring routine in Qualtrics. Inclusion required elevated anxiety and at least one area of functional impairment. Exclusion criteria were current elevated depression, likely PTSD, likely psychosis-spectrum experiences, and failure of embedded attention-check items.

Included if: - OASIS total > 4 (elevated anxiety), AND - At least one WSAS item scored above 2 (at least one functional domain meaningfully impaired).

Excluded if: - PHQ-9 total (excluding the embedded attention-check item) > 14 (moderately severe depression or higher), OR - Brief PCL-5 total > 6 (elevated post-traumatic symptoms), OR - Endorsement of either of two DIAMOND screening items for delusional or hallucinatory experiences, OR - Any failed embedded attention-check item (wsas_4, phq_3).

All of the measures used in eligibility decisions are described in their respective sections below.

Symptom and functioning measures

OASIS — Overall Anxiety Severity and Impairment Scale

5 items. Primary outcome; assessed at every timepoint.

Instructions. "The following questions ask about anxiety and fear. For each question, circle the number for the answer that best describes your experience over the *past week*."

Response anchors. Each item has its own behaviourally anchored 5-point scale (0–4). For example, item 1 ranges from 0 = "No anxiety in the past week" to 4 = "Constant anxiety. Felt anxious all of the time and never really relaxed." Anchors for all items are given in the source publication.

Citation. Norman et al. (2006).

WSAS — Work and Social Adjustment Scale

5 items (the scored items; an additional sixth position in the Qualtrics matrix is an embedded attention-check item, excluded from scoring). Secondary outcome; assessed at screening, session 1, session 4, and both follow-ups.

Instructions. "People's problems sometimes affect their ability to do certain day-to-day tasks in their lives. To rate your problems, look at each section and determine on the scale provided how much your problem impairs your ability to carry out the activity. 0 indicates no impairment at all and 8 indicates very severe impairment."

Domains. Work, home management, social leisure activities, private leisure activities, family and relationships.

Response anchors. 9-point scale (0–8) with endpoint anchors only: 0 = "Not at all," 8 = "Very severely impaired." Intermediate points are numeric. The attention-check item at position 4 in the Qualtrics matrix ("please respond with 'not at all' in this item and continue to the next item") is excluded from the WSAS total.

Citation. Mundt et al. (2002).

PHQ-9 — Patient Health Questionnaire-9

9 items (the scored items; a tenth position in the Qualtrics matrix is an embedded attention-check item, excluded from scoring). Screening only; used for depression-based exclusion.

Instructions. "Over the last 2 weeks, how often have you been bothered by any of the following problems?"

Response anchors. 0 = "Not at all," 1 = "Several days," 2 = "More than half the days," 3 = "Nearly every day." The attention-check item at position 3 in the Qualtrics matrix ("please respond with 'Nearly every day' in this item and continue to the next item") is excluded from the PHQ-9 total.

Citation. Kroenke et al. (2009).

Brief PCL-5 — 4-item PTSD screener

4 items, administered conditionally to participants who endorsed a gateway trauma-exposure question ("Have you experienced [a list of qualifying events]?"). Screening only; used for trauma-based exclusion.

Instructions (gateway). "This questionnaire asks about problems you may have had after a very stressful experience involving actual or threatened death, serious injury, or sexual violence. It could be something that happened to you directly, something you witnessed, or something you learned happened to a close family member or close friend. Have you experienced one of the following? Fire; disaster such as a hurricane, tornado, or earthquake; physical or sexual attack or abuse; war; homicide; or suicide."

Instructions (items). "Below is a list of problems that people sometimes have in response to a very stressful experience. Please read each problem carefully and then indicate how much you have been bothered by that problem in the past month."

Response anchors. 0 = "Not at all," 1 = "A little bit," 2 = "Moderately," 3 = "Quite a bit," 4 = "Extremely." This is a 4-item brief version covering reexperiencing, avoidance, emotional numbing, and irritability/aggression.

Citation. Zuromski et al. (2019). The brief 4-item form corresponds to items 1, 6, 12, and 16 of the full 20-item PCL-5.

DIAMOND delusion and hallucination items

2 items (items 19 and 20 of the DIAMOND self-report screener). Screening only; used for psychosis-based exclusion.

Instructions. "Please answer the following: I have had very strong beliefs in something that other people thought were strange, such as any of the following: [list of seven example beliefs]" (delusion item) and "I have had sensory experiences that others could not understand, such as: [list of two example sensory experiences]" (hallucination item).

Response anchors. Binary (Yes/No; 0/1).

Citation. Tolin et al. (2018).

Hypothesised mechanisms

Administered at sessions 1 and 4 only, except for BSAM which is administered at every session and at both follow-ups (see its entry below).

DTS — Distress Tolerance Scale

14 items (item 6 of the originally 15-item DTS was dropped due to a data-collection error that duplicated item 7).

Instructions. "Think of times that you feel distressed or upset. Select the item that best describes your beliefs about feeling distressed or upset."

Response anchors. 1 = "Strongly agree," 2 = "Mildly agree," 3 = "Agree and disagree equally," 4 = "Mildly disagree," 5 = "Strongly disagree."

Citation. Simons and Gaher (2005).

TAF-R — Thought-Action Fusion Scale, Revised

19 items, yielding two subscales: TAF-Moral (12 items) and TAF-Likelihood (7 items). The precise item-subscale assignments used here are documented in the data codebook under `taf_m` and `taf_l`.

Instructions. "Below is a list of statements. Please rate your level of agreement or disagreement with each statement."

Response anchors. 0 = "Disagree strongly," 1 = "Disagree," 2 = "Neither agree nor disagree," 3 = "Agree," 4 = "Agree strongly."

Citation. Shafran, Thordarson, and Rachman (1996).

BCSS — Brief Core Schema Scales

24 items yielding four 6-item subscales: Self-Negative (items 1–6), Self-Positive (items 7–12), Other-Negative (items 13–18), Other-Positive (items 19–24).

Instructions. "Below are some statements about beliefs that people can have about themselves and about others. Please indicate which of these beliefs apply to you, and how strongly you hold the belief."

Response anchors. 0 = "No," 1 = "Yes, a little," 2 = "Yes, moderately," 3 = "Yes, strongly," 4 = "Yes, very strongly."

Citation. Fowler et al. (2006).

IFES — Impact of Future Events Scale

24 items.

Instructions. "Please read each statement and rate how much you agree with it, referring to your feelings about future events you are worried about."

Response anchors. 1 = "Not at all true," 2 = "Slightly true," 3 = "Moderately true," 4 = "Very true," 5 = "Extremely true."

Citation. Deeprose, Malik, and Holmes (2011).

MCQ-30 — Metacognitions Questionnaire, short form

30 items yielding five 6-item subscales: Positive Beliefs about Worry, Negative Beliefs about the Uncontrollability of Thoughts and Danger, Cognitive Confidence, Beliefs about the Need to Control Thoughts, Cognitive Self-Consciousness. The precise item-subscale assignments used here are documented in the data codebook under the `mcq_*` measure names.

Instructions. "This questionnaire is concerned with beliefs people have about their thinking. Listed below are a number of beliefs that people have expressed. Please read each item and say how much you generally agree with it."

Response anchors. 1 = "Do not agree," 2 = "Agree slightly," 3 = "Agree moderately," 4 = "Agree very much."

Citation. Wells and Cartwright-Hatton (2004).

SCS-SF — Self-Compassion Scale, Short Form

12 items.

Instructions. "How I typically act towards myself in difficult times. Please read each statement carefully before answering. Indicate how often you behave in the stated manner."

Response anchors. 1 = "Almost never," 2, 3, 4, 5 = "Almost always" (5-point scale with endpoint anchors only; intermediate points are numeric).

Citation. Raes et al. (2011).

BSAM — Brief State Anxiety Measure

6 items, administered both before and after each writing task (at every session) and pre-writing at both follow-ups (to the same imagined core-threat script). Items 1, 2, and 4 ("I feel relaxed," "I feel steady," "I feel comfortable") are reverse-scored; reverse-scoring is already applied in the `value` column of `data_long.csv` (see data codebook).

Instructions (pre-writing). "Please take a few seconds to imagine your short script as if it is happening right now. When you have managed to get a clear image, please press continue to answer a few questions. [script displayed] A number of statements that people have used to describe themselves are given below. Read each statement and then choose the appropriate number to indicate how you feel *right now*, at this moment. There are no right or wrong answers. Do not spend too much time on any one statement, but give the answer which seems to describe your present feelings best."

Instructions (post-writing). Same as above.

Items (verbatim). "I feel relaxed"; "I feel steady"; "I feel strained"; "I feel comfortable"; "I feel worried"; "I feel tense."

Response anchors. 1 = "Strongly disagree," 2 = "Disagree," 3 = "Somewhat disagree," 4 = "Neither agree nor disagree," 5 = "Somewhat agree," 6 = "Agree," 7 = "Strongly agree."

Citation. Berg et al. (1998). A short adaptation of the state subscale of the State-Trait Anxiety Inventory (Spielberger, 1983).

Intervention procedure

Core-threat elicitation (CTSI)

A structured self-administered protocol used to identify each participant's idiosyncratic core threat and produce a short threat script for use in subsequent writing sessions (Zlotnick and Huppert 2026). Administered only at session 1 of the active arms (WET and NIW); waitlist participants did not receive the CTSI.

The full protocol text (subjective-units-of-distress rating procedure, the "magic wand" fear-selection question, the threat-laddering table with worked examples, the core-threat identification and emotional-avoidance probes, the safety-behaviour checklist, and the "connect the dots" script-composition exercise) is provided as a separate file: ctsi.pdf (source: ctsi.Rmd).

Treatment Credibility Questionnaire (CEQ)

Devilly & Borkovec's Credibility/Expectancy Questionnaire. Administered once, immediately after the WET or NIW rationale in session 1, as a manipulation check.

Instructions. "We would like you to indicate below how much you believe, *right now*, that the therapy you are receiving will help to reduce your anxiety. Belief usually has two aspects to it: (1) what one thinks will happen and (2) what one feels will happen. Sometimes these are similar; sometimes they are different. Please answer the questions below."

Items. 4 "think" items (logicality, expected success, recommendation to a friend, expected improvement) followed by 2 "feel" items (felt helpfulness, felt expected improvement). Full items are in the source publication.

Response anchors. 1–9 scale; for the "think" items, 1 = "Not at all logical / useful" and 9 = "Very logical / useful" depending on the item; for the "feel" items, 1 = "Not at all" and 9 = "Very much." Intermediate points are numeric.

Citation. Devilly and Borkovec (2000).

Written Exposure Therapy (WET) psychoeducation and writing

Administered to participants randomized to WET, once per session (four sessions). Psychoeducation appears only in session 1; sessions 2–4 repeat the writing task with brief refresher instructions.

The full psychoeducation text, writing-principle guidelines, and 20-minute timed writing prompt are in instructions.wet.pdf (source: instructions.wet.Rmd).

Neutral Imagery Writing (NIW) psychoeducation and writing

Administered to participants randomized to NIW (active control). Same schedule as WET.

The full psychoeducation text, writing-principle guidelines, and 20-minute writing prompt are in instructions.niw.pdf (source: instructions.niw.Rmd).

Fear-script evaluation items

Five self-designed items administered immediately before and after each writing session, alongside the BSAM. These items probe beliefs about the core-threat script itself. They were collected but are not analysed in this report.

Instructions. "Please rate to what extent you agree with each of the following statements."

Items (verbatim). "I believe that the events in my script are likely to happen"; "It would be terrible if the events in my script come to be"; "Imagining my script was stressful"; "My image was vivid and rich with sensory details"; "My imagined scenario was clear and coherent."

Response anchors. 7-point scale: 1 = "Strongly disagree," 2 = "Disagree," 3 = "Somewhat disagree," 4 = "Neither agree nor disagree," 5 = "Somewhat agree," 6 = "Agree," 7 = "Strongly agree."

Post-writing and session-wrap items

Reflection questions (WET and NIW)

Three open-ended reflection questions administered at the end of each writing session:

1. "Did you learn anything about yourself or your fears while writing? Did it give you a new perspective or a new way of thinking about things? If so, what did you learn?"
2. "Did you notice anything surprising, or something that did not make sense in what you wrote? If so, what was it?"
3. "If you had to do a writing task like this again, would you do anything different? What would it be? (Would you focus on something else? Would you change your style?)"

These are also reproduced as part of instructions.wet.Rmd and instructions.niw .Rmd.

Commitment-to-return item

Single item administered at the end of sessions 1–4; asks about commitment to returning for the next contact point. Labelled `commitment` in `data_long.csv`.

Stem. "Your involvement in this study is immensely valuable, and we truly appreciate your contribution to our research. Given the significance of your

contributions, we are interested in knowing how committed you feel about returning for the next phase of data collection."

Response anchors. 1 = "Not at all committed," 2 = "Slightly committed," 3 = "Moderately committed," 4 = "Very committed," 5 = "Extremely committed."

End-of-session debrief

Brief text displayed at the end of each session. The writing-session debrief (sessions 1–4) acknowledges the difficulty of the task, normalises post-session distress, and previews the next session:

> "Well done! You have successfully completed Part [N] of the 'Writing to cope with anxiety' experiment. Part [N+1] will be accessible on your Prolific homepage in one day, and you will have 48 hours to complete it. [...] It's possible that you feel stressed and agitated after this session. This is a natural response, as you have just dealt with difficult content that you may usually avoid. This may even be a positive sign that you have touched upon something significant for you. Additionally, in the next few days, you may have thoughts, images, and feelings related to the fears you've written about. It's important to allow yourself to experience them and not push them away. Simply pay attention when they come up, and remember that they will pass."

The session-4 debrief previews the one-week follow-up rather than a further writing session. The one-week follow-up debrief is a short thank-you for completing the study. The two-month follow-up debrief is longer and includes a study-purpose summary and acknowledgement of the participant's contribution.

Follow-up sessions

One-week follow-up

Administered seven days after session 4. Participants completed, in order:

- Consent
- BSAM (pre-writing format, while imagining the same core-threat script they had worked with during the intervention)
- Fear-script evaluation items (5 items, not analysed)
- OASIS
- WSAS
- A short thank-you debrief

No psychoeducation, no writing task, no post-writing BSAM, no commitment item, no fear-script evaluation post. Instructions and anchors for each measure are identical to those used at session 1 and given above.

Two-month follow-up

Administered approximately two months after the one-week follow-up. Same content as the one-week follow-up, with the additions of:

- TIII (administered for purposes outside the scope of this report; not analysed)
- Two open-ended items about the intervention's impact on everyday life and any skill transfer (analysed qualitatively; item text given in Qualitative feedback items below)
- An extended debrief section

Qualitative feedback items

Three open-ended prompts collected after the intervention are analysed qualitatively (with some quantitative summary) in the manuscript. These are distinct from the session-wrap reflection questions described above (which were collected at the end of each writing session and are not analysed in this report).

Study-feedback prompt (session 4)

A single open-ended text item administered at the end of session 4, immediately before the debrief.

Prompt. "We appreciate your participation in this questionnaire, which is an initial step towards developing a clinical therapeutic intervention for anxiety disorders. Your feedback is important to us. Were the instructions clear? How did you feel during the writing task? Did you find it helpful in any way? Was there any specific instruction or question that left an impression on you?"

Response format. Free text (multi-line).

Impact and skill-transfer prompts (two-month follow-up)

Two open-ended text items administered at the two-month follow-up, before the debrief.

Impact prompt. "How has the intervention affected your life, if at all? Please describe any changes or benefits that you have noticed in your mood, behavior, relationships, or functioning since completing the intervention."

Skill-transfer prompt. "Did you apply the skills that you learned in the study to other situations? If so, how did you do that?"

Response format. Free text (multi-line).

Materials administered but not analysed in this report

The following measures and probes were administered but are not analysed or reported in this study. They played no role in the present hypotheses or results, and we do not reproduce their item content here.

- **Imaginal Behavior Approach Test (iBAT).** An experimental behavioural measure involving audio-stimulus calibration followed by imagery-based approach trials. Administered at sessions 1 and 4 per the preregistration. The measure did not yield usable data in the present sample and is not analyzed or reported.
- **Thought Intrusion Intensity Instrument (TIII).** An experimental measure collected at sessions 1, 4, and the two-month follow-up for purposes outside the scope of this report.
- **Self-Appraisal of Illness Questionnaire (SAIQ).** Administered at sessions 1 and 4 for purposes outside the scope of this report.
- **A self-report insight measure (labelled `insight SR` in the survey export).** Administered at sessions 1 and 4 for purposes outside the scope of this report.
- **Fear-script evaluation items.** A 5-item matrix probing beliefs about the core-threat script (likelihood, valence, stressfulness, vividness, coherence). Administered before and after every writing session and pre-writing at both follow-ups, alongside the BSAM. We document the content above (Intervention procedure) because the matrix sits in the main session flow alongside the BSAM and could otherwise be confused with it. Not analysed in this report.
- **Within-writing distress slider.** A single-item visual analogue distress rating administered during every writing session. Not analysed.
- **Daily belief and behaviour probes (sessions 2 and 3).** Two brief slider-style matrices probing beliefs and behaviour during the preceding day. Intended as an abbreviated alternative to the full mechanism battery for repeat sessions; not analysed.
- **Nightmare-description block (session 4).** A self-designed block asking participants about a nightmare. Administered, but neither preregistered nor analysed.

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